

Photo illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

IDENTIFYING THE VICTIMS

How the CBI's Online Child Sexual Abuse & Exploitation (OCSAE) prevention/ investigation unit works

The OCSAE unit keeps checking for Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM) on messenger services, livestreaming apps, cloud services and social media platforms besides suspect transactions via crypto and e-wallets

It also has access to the Interpol's International Child Sexual Exploitation (ICSE) database with over 4.3 million CSAM seized by law enforcement agencies worldwide

In a blind case, investigators first try to parse any language or dialect that crops up in the video. Then they minutely examine objects in the video to zero in on the location

Advanced cyber forensic tools can also reveal the precise GPS location where an image/ video was shot, as well as its date and time

TRACKING THE OFFENDERS

The CBI conducted its most successful operation against CSAM—Megh Chakra—in Sept. 2022. Here's how it zeroed in on 66 offenders



The Digital Child Exploitation Team of New Zealand, investigating a complaint about a cloud storage link associated with Mega.nz, finds an embedded subfolder that contains five CSAM video clips

Interpol's Crime Against Children Unit based in Singapore refers this link to the CBI

The CBI tracks 141 email IDs—102 belonging to Google/Yahoo and the remaining 39 to other domains like protonmail—located in India that had accessed and downloaded the clips through the link

The CBI homes in on 66 persons, after identifying mobile numbers linked to these email IDs or via IP addresses

The agency raids 61 locations in 21 states and UTs across India. CSAM videos found on the mobiles and other devices of 33 out of those 66